

The list is safe in our hands. And then word comes to us of the river — of a body the watermen pulled from the shallows in the night and left lying, because no one came to claim it.

We did not need to be told twice whose body it was. The worn coat. The ink still on the fingers. R. — the contact who was never where he should have been, who left us a scrap and a sealed letter and then nothing at all. He did not flee the city. He never had the chance.

A boatman, face-down in the mud — while the great men whose errands he ran sleep warm behind their walls tonight. The letter was never his. The cause was never his. He only carried. Carrying is what killed him. That is how it goes for small men caught in the schemes of large ones: they do the carrying, and they do the dying, and the men who gain by it never learn their names.

They found something on him, the watermen — a small instrument, the kind a river man keeps for the long hours on the water; and folded with it, a scrap in his hand. The same hand as the note he left us. Not a message, this time. A tune, set down note by note, and beneath it his last words:

They took the dispatch off me. I could not keep it — so I hid it where only our own would think to look. Play my tune true and you will have the number that opens the way to it. Play it as I played it to the river, note for note.

And here is the strange of it. As we read his hand, the tune is somehow already in the air — drifting in off the cold water, with no player anywhere in sight. The way the old tale tells of a raftsman whose playing once drew the whole town's plague of frogs down the bank and under the Vistula. As if the river had kept his music for him, and gives it back now that he cannot.

No one marks it. The whole city is piping and drumming itself hoarse tonight; one more tune off the water is nothing at all. So we listen. We take up his instrument and we follow the tune note for note, writing down each number as it sounds.

Six numbers. The number R_6 died keeping. We carry it back — and we will be given what he hid.